

Habitat & Cultivation

Squaw vine is native to the eastern and central U.S. It grows in dry sites in woodlands, and is harvested in late summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, berries.

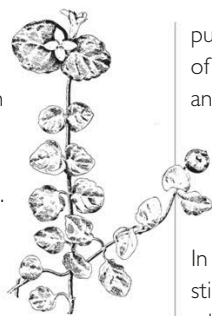
Constituents Squaw vine is believed to contain tannins, glycosides, and saponins.

History & Folklore

An infusion of squaw vine was commonly taken by Native American women to hasten childbirth. It was also occasionally used for a variety of other complaints, including insomnia, rheumatic pain, and fluid retention.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Squaw vine is still extensively used to aid labor and childbirth, and is considered to have a tonic action on the uterus and the ovaries. It is taken to normalize menstruation and to relieve heavy periods and period pain. This herb has also been recommended for stimulating breast-milk production, but other herbs with a similar action, such as fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212), are preferred. The berries, crushed and mixed with tincture of myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), are helpful for sore nipples. An astringent herb, squaw vine has also been prescribed for diarrhea and colitis.

Caution Do not take during the first 6 months of pregnancy.



Aerial parts

Momordica charantia (Cucurbitaceae)

Bitter Melon, Kerala

Description Annual climber growing to about 6½ ft (2 m). Has deeply lobed leaves, yellow flowers, and orange-yellow fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Asia, bitter melon is common throughout tropical regions of the world. It is harvested year round.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit, seeds, seed oil.

Constituents Bitter melon contains a fixed oil, an insulin-like peptide, cucurbitacins, glycosides (mormordin and charantin), and an alkaloid (mormordicine). The peptide is known to lower sugar levels in the blood and urine.

History & Folklore Bitter melon is traditionally taken in Asia, Africa, and the Caribbean to treat the symptoms of diabetes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The unripe fruit is mainly used to treat type 2 diabetes. The ripe fruit is a stomach tonic, and induces menstruation. In Turkey, it is used to treat ulcers. The fruit is much used in the West Indies for worms, urinary stones, and fever. The fruit juice is taken as a

purgative, and is prescribed for colic. A decoction of the leaves is taken for liver problems and colitis, and it may be applied to skin conditions. The seed oil is used to help heal wounds.

Research Seeds are androgenic and inhibit sperm production, and were tested as a contraceptive in China in the 1980s.

In diabetic laboratory animals, the fruit juice stimulated regeneration of the pancreatic cells, which secrete insulin. A major body of evidence now supports the traditional use of the fruit juice to treat non-insulin-dependent diabetes.

Related Species The seeds of the Asian *M. cochinchinensis* are applied as a poultice to relieve abscesses, hemorrhoids, and scrofula. Recent research indicates that a paste of the seeds may help psoriasis and ringworm.

Cautions While bitter melon is relatively safe at low dosage, do not use for more than 4 weeks. Do not take if prone to low blood-sugar levels.

Monarda punctata (Lamiaceae) Horsemint

Description Strongly aromatic perennial growing to 3 ft (90 cm). Has downy lance-shaped leaves, and double-lipped, red-spotted yellow flowers growing in whorls from the leaf axils.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the eastern and central U.S., horsemint is found in dry and sandy areas. It is gathered when in flower in summer and autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Horsemint's volatile oil has thymol as the main constituent.



Horsemint strongly encourages sweating and the onset of menstruation.

History & Folklore Horsemint's genus name, *Monarda*, was bestowed in honor of Nicolas Monardes, a Spanish physician, whose herbal of 1569 detailed the medicinal uses of a number of New World plants. Horsemint was used by the

Winnebagos and Dakotas as a stimulant and as a treatment for cholera. Other Native Americans used the herb for a wide variety of problems, including nausea, backache, fluid retention, chills, and headache.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Having a strong volatile oil, horsemint is primarily used for digestive and upper respiratory problems. It is taken as an infusion to relieve nausea, indigestion, flatulence, and colic. It is also employed to reduce fevers and upper respiratory mucus. The herb has an antiseptic action within the chest. Taken internally or applied externally, horsemint reduces fever by encouraging sweating. It also strongly stimulates menstruation.

Related Species In 19th-century America, Oswego tea (*M. didyma*) was considered a tonic for young mothers, and was traditionally given to brides. It is thought to be a mild menstrual regulator and an appetite stimulant.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Monsonia ovata (Geraniaceae) Monsonia

Description Small herbaceous plant with multi-branched stems, very small oblong leaves and white solitary or paired geranium-like flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to South Africa and Namibia, monsonia is found growing in arid conditions. It is gathered when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

History & Folklore In Zulu medicine, monsonia is used to treat snake bite.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Monsonia is used throughout southwestern Africa as a treatment for diarrhea, acute and chronic dysentery, and ulcerative colitis. The plant's astringent properties act to tighten and protect the inner linings of the intestinal tract. Given monsonia's long traditional use for intestinal disorders and infections, it is possible—but as yet unsubstantiated by research—that the plant has a direct antimicrobial effect.

Montia perfoliata (Portulacaceae) Miner's Lettuce

Description Annual growing to 4 in (10 cm) with pointed oval leaves (one pair enveloping the stem), and white 5-petaled flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Miner's lettuce is native to western North America, and has become naturalized in temperate regions around the world, especially in Australia. The plant thrives in acid sandy soils. It is generally gathered from